THE SELF AS AESTHETIC:

NIETZCHE IN THUS SPOKE ZARATHUSTRA

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The influence of Friedrich Nietzsche spans widely over the disciplines of philosophy, law, history, and art – not only because his writings comment on each of these fields, but because his thought synthesised novel and even revolutionary ideas across these disciplines. In particular, Nietzsche declared that life is essentially meaninglessness and hence dismissed the ideals of an objective, universal morality; instead, he suggested that people must create their own meaning in life, and undertake this attempt of being an 'authentic' individual as an artistic or aesthetic endeavour. In the following essay, I will first conduct an in-depth explanation of Nietzsche's aesthetics and its culmination in his philosophy of the performance of an authentic self; further, I will propose that Nietzsche's own authentic self is reified in a literary, aesthetic form through his seminal work, 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra'.

Performing an Authentic Self

Nietzsche's philosophy is characterised by a preoccupation with the function of art and aesthetics as an expression of the human essence – indeed, his first published work, 'The Birth of Tragedy' (1872), encompasses an analysis of the art of ancient Greek tragedies. Here, he examines ancient Greek culture and its relation to the birth of the form of Greek tragedy. He defines the opposing dichotomy of the 'Apollonian' and 'Dionysian' aspects of art, and asserts that the perfect amalgamation of the Apollonian and Dionysian, which can be found in Greek tragedies, are "an adequate means of coping with life's pains and pointlessness" (Goh 2024).

The Apollonian aspect of art represents appearances or, more accurately, the deception of appearances. This aspect of art arises from and applies itself to the act of a deliberate construction of appearance, "the beautiful appearance of the inner world of the imagination" (Nietzsche 1872, 1). These constructed forms hence align themselves to the idea of control and its manifestations, such as discipline, order, structure, reason, logic, systems. By association, we can apprehend that the Apollonian is restrained, moderate, calm, still, regal,

and dignified. It is seen in control and containment – the idea of a boundary that provides definition. Apollonian artworks (such as architecture, sculpture, painting, poetry) all lend themselves to a perfect and controlled order of creation, a *construction* of beauty. On the other hand, the Dionysian challenges the order of the Apollonian. The Dionysian aspect of art manifests itself in chaos, wildness, irrationality, cruelty, struggle, intoxication, and ecstasy. It can be aligned with descriptors such as uncertainty, excessiveness, ambiguity, vagueness, savageness, mystique, and resistance to categorizations. It is that which lies outside the Apollonian boundary, "without the mediation of the human artist" (Nietzsche 1872, 2), which cannot be controlled, subjugated, tamed, or even objectified. The epitome of Dionysian art is music – it cannot be bounded or measured, it is transient, only experienced in the moment.

On Nietzsche's view, it is in Greek tragic theatre that the Apollonian and Dionysian attain the perfect balance – the Apollonian through the narrative drama of the act, and the Dionysian through the interspersal of the musical chorus in the course of the play. The Dionysian is irrevocably present in the play's chorus that punctuates the Apollonian sequence of events on the stage. There is a push-and-pull across the spectrum of Apollonian to Dionysian, and this format allows a Dionysian freedom to indulge or filter itself through an Apollonian construction. If the Dionysian overwhelms us with "the joy experienced in the annihilation of the individual" (Nietzsche 1872, 16), the Apollonian "like a mighty Titan, relieves us of the burden of the Dionysian world by taking it on his shoulders" (Nietzsche 1872, 21).

The catharsis of tragedy is thus in the union of the Apollonian and Dionysian – despite the suffering represented in the play, the experience of the play becomes a therapeutic experience. The form of the tragic play itself symbolizes the ancient Greek appetite for life, despite their having an acute awareness of its pointlessness. It is for this reason that Nietzsche applauds the ancient Greeks – they see the depth of the metaphysical thing-in-itself, the

Dionysian, that signals the meaninglessness of life, yet continue to create and imbibe meaning in their lives through the construction of the Apollonian. In short, the Greeks perfected the ability to create meaning in the face of life's pointless suffering through aesthetic form.

Over a decade later in 'The Gay Science' (1888), Nietzsche revisited this impulse of the ancient Greeks to look past life's suffering by creating art; however, this time, he goes a step further – he posits that this aestheticizing quality may even be the solution for the contemporary, modern human to reconcile their own pointless suffering of life and in the process, create an 'authentic' self. In the preface to the second edition, he writes:

> "Those Greeks! They knew how to live: what is needed for that is to stop bravely at the surface, the fold, the skin; to worship appearance, to believe in shapes, tones, words - in the whole Olympus of appearance! Those Greeks were superficial - out of profundity! And is not this precisely what we are coming back to, we daredevils of the spirit who have climbed the highest and most dangerous peak of current thought and looked around from up there, looked down from up there? Are we not just in this respect - Greeks? Worshippers of shapes, tones, words? And therefore - artists?" (Nietzsche 1888, Preface 4).

Part of the Greek excellence in living life was their ability to see deeply at the pointlessness of life and still *choose* to believe in meanings they created in their plays. Their superficial concern (with aesthetics) is charged with profundity (. Nietzsche says that the people who choose to challenge the norms of society in his time, then, are also like the Greeks – after they strip away the impositions of culture and society, they instead look at life as something that they created. To this extent, their ability to aestheticize has made them akin to artists.

Nietzsche asserts that it is only "as an aesthetic phenomenon [that] existence is still bearable to us" (Nietzsche 1888, 107). Developing this idea further, Nietzsche goes on to say

that life's suffering can be overcome by the creation of an authentic self; and that this creation is necessarily an aesthetic process. An authentic self requires us to take away any sociocultural meaning imposed onto ourselves and our traits, and to simply see ourselves as we are and our traits as part of ourselves. This taking away of imposed meaning is best achieved through an "artistic distance" (Nietzsche 1888, 107), because it is through art that we can see things in their essence. We must become able to see ourselves the way we see an aesthetic object or form, "simplified and transfigured […] from a distance and as something past and whole" (Nietzsche 1888, 78). Once we are able to do this, our flaws become just another unqualified part of our greater aesthetic self.

The aesthetic self functions as the organization of the chaos of our being under a single idea or drive. Each part of the self is shaped to contribute and magnify this aesthetic idea, to "fit them into an artistic plan until each appears as art and reason and even weaknesses delight the eye" (Nietzsche 1888, 290). The aesthetic self, which is shaped, fashioned and styled by us, is therefore the most individual form of the self as it solely belongs to us – through both the initial removal of sociocultural impositions from our perspective on the self as well as the deliberate creative process of the authentic self. Importantly, this aesthetic self is not static, but a constantly changing form – it takes on new organizing drives as people overcome different parts of themselves.

The emphasis on aestheticism and the creation of an authentic self is not a passing thought, but constantly emphasized and reiterated across Nietzsche's works. It seems that Nietzsche himself must have engaged in this aesthetic self-making that he preaches – it is in this vein that, in the next section, I argue that we can observe and analyse Nietzsche's own aesthetic self (at least, as it was in 1883) as it takes shape in his book, 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra'.

Zarathustra as Authentic Performance

So far, I have attempted to give a framework of Nietzsche's philosophy on aesthetics as it bears on the view of the self as authentic. Here, aesthetics takes on an important role in detaching the self from the impositions of the external world – such as its tendency to denotate things that are morally good or bad. Instead, aesthetic form is free from these denotations, facilitating a creation of meaning in pursuit of something *beautiful*, rather than something considered good. And, it follows, if the self can take on an aesthetic form, it can equally be apprehended as an aesthetic form.

The tendency of the self to express itself and its changing manifestations within aesthetic form can be seen in the margins of all of Nietzsche's work. For instance, 'The Birth of Tragedy' had two published editions – the first written in 1871 when Nietzsche believed that the Greek art of the tragic play could be viably reincarnated through the operas of his then-friend Richard Wagner, the second in 1886 after his disillusionment with Wagner's art, and further foray into the field of philosophy. The second edition contains a preface to the main text, titled 'An Attempt at Self-Criticism', where we see Nietzsche confront himself through the aesthetic form of his own writing. In this sense, this essay is partially a reification of Nietzsche's own self-overcoming – he revises or reframes the aesthetic form of his past self, acknowledging its limitations as stemming from "merely premature, really immature personal experiences" and "with every fault of youth" (2). Nietzsche's position in this piece is that of a more developed self looking back at itself, a self-reflection made possible only through the aesthetic form of a book, and "how strangely after sixteen years it stands there in front of [him]" (2).

I use this example only to illustrate my larger point: that books, even – and perhaps especially – those of philosophy, are very much an aesthetic form that the Nietzschean authentic self can take on. The question, then, becomes whether Nietzsche himself dedicated

to creating a reified, aesthetic form as an expression of his authentic self. In the present section, I argue that his seminal masterpiece 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra'[1], his most ambiguous and enigmatic work, can take the place of an aestheticized form of the then-Nietzsche.

In the first place, 'Zarathustra' is irrevocably distinct from the rest of Nietzsche's writings, what scholar Robert Pippin calls "the basic problem of Zarathustra" (as in Seung 2005). It follows a narrative that centres on a character, the titular Zarathustra, on his journey to being a prophet to humankind. However, as outlined in Seung (2005), this narrative is neither clear nor consistent, with different parts of the book jarringly moving from the events unfolding in Zarathustra's lived experience to his musing thoughts and sermons. It has been contended that the entirety of Part IV of the book belongs to a different genre than the first three parts and should be read as so (Seung 2005). Indeed, even his sections of sermons do not easily consent to being defined as such – there are speeches which are simply an outpouring of words or emotions, only tied together and recognised even as dialogue at the end with the recurring declaration "— Thus spoke Zarathustra". Different sections of the book call out and refer back to others with little order or coherence, even contradicting each other at times, making a holistic analysis of 'Zarathustra' difficult. As a book, 'Zarathustra' resists any categorization, it is a "a tragedy, a comedy, and even a parody" all in one (Seung 2005, Preface).

'Zarathustra' is thus a literary aesthetic form perhaps only in the loosest of terms; it may be said that its loose grasp on the claim to aesthetics corresponds to a loose grasp on the claim to being a representation of Nietzsche's authentic self. However, I argue that it is precisely this aspect of 'Zarathustra' that lends itself to the essence of the authentic self – the discontinuity, the resistance to categorization, the inherent incoherence of the book all elicit

[1] Hereafter referred to as 'Zarathustra' with quotations. Without quotations, Zarathustra refers to the character.

aspects of the laudable Dionysian we saw in 'The Birth of Tragedy'. This reading is cemented in section 342 of 'The Gay Science', where Nietzsche introduces Zarathustra and summarizes what would be the prologue of 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra'. Aptly, this section is titled 'The tragedy begins' (Latin: *Incipit tragoedia*), highlighting that Nietzsche himself thought of 'Zarathustra' as a tragedy, and Zarathustra as a tragic hero. According to Seung (2005), it is this premise that allows us to glimpse a way of categorizing or assigning genre to 'Zarathustra' – rather than a tragedy, we "want to classify Nietzsche's long poem as an epic" (Preface).

The epic, then, is the story of Nietzsche himself as analogous to Zarathustra. The incoherence that characterises 'Zarathustra', far from a flaw, now becomes an aesthetic choice. Seen as an epic rather than a doctrine of philosophy, we can apprehend the Dionysian chaos, irrationality, and excessiveness within 'Zarathustra' as a signal or symbol of the authentic self. In a way, Nietzsche is attempting to recreate the perfection of the Greek tragedy – the Apollonian form of the narrative novel itself is constantly undercut by the discordant sections of speeches and aphorisms which contradict each other in a Dionysian fashion. The Dionysian impulse of The words of the book should not and cannot be taken as literal, because it is in its position in Nietzsche's oeuvre, the book itself is layered with an irony built into its very form, and this irony seeps into the work as a whole.

Conclusion

In this essay, I have attempted to demonstrate that the authentic self which takes on an aesthetic form can be seen in Nietzsche's own writing of 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra'. When one sees the world as a system of sociocultural impositions, life loses meaning and becomes a pointless suffering. Nietzsche offers us redemption by encouraging us to see ourselves as an aesthetic project, in which flaws are not good or bad, they are simply an aesthetic inherent to the work. Though 'Thus Spoke Zarathustra', Nietzsche perfects the organization of the

inherent chaos and pointlessness of the self under a single unifying structure. It is in the complexity of ‘Zarathustra’ that Nietzsche reconciles the Dionysian chaos with an Apollonian order, and hence performs his authentic self.

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